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A team's AI success says the least about the person you were surest of

When no one can see who did what, even an honest sponsor tends to split the credit by what they already believed. Credit each person only for the parts you can point to.



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THE CENTRAL ARGUMENT

When an AI program succeeds and no one can see who did what, even an honest sponsor tends to split the credit by what they already believed about each person. A team success can then seem to confirm that view; it lifts the whole team, and most the people already rated highest. A result tells you something new about a person only where it differs from what you expected, so it should change your view of the person you were surest of the least. Credit each person only for the parts you can point to, and credit the rest to the team equally.

An AI program you sponsor has delivered. Many people worked on it: the program lead, the people who built the tool, the people who prepared the data, the managers who changed how the work is done. Now you have to decide what the result says about each of them. It will feed recognition, promotions and who leads the next program. You know credit is political. Leaders and well-known people tend to collect it, and everyone tells their own part well. So you discount the loudest claims, ask several people what happened, and form your own view from what you saw. Underneath sits a reasonable belief: once you have corrected for the people who claim too much, your own honest reading of who drove the result is roughly right.

The trouble is not only in the people who claim credit. It is in the person dividing it. In joint work, no one can see who did what beyond the parts anyone can point to. Studies of how people divide joint results find that, in that unseen part, even an honest judge tilts the split toward what they already believed about each person. The same judges treat people alike when each person's part is visible. So a team success can seem to confirm your view of each person. It lifts the whole team, and it lifts most the people you already rated highest.

That leads to a conclusion that runs against instinct. A result tells you something new about a person only to the extent it differs from what you expected of them. Take the person you were surest of before this result, the one whose strength you were most confident of. For that person, the success was mostly expected, so it should change your view of them the least. Yet the usual way of dividing credit, as the studies below show for people judges already favor, gives them the most.

What to do instead: raise a person's standing, your settled view of how strong they are, on a joint success only for the parts you or a record can point to, even for the person you are sure drove it. Credit the rest to the team, equally to every member. For that to work,

the parts have to be written down while the work is done and confirmed by the people named, and you have to read that record before you form your view.

ARGUMENT AT A GLANCE

What a sponsor should credit after a joint AI success

What fills the unseen split

Even an honest judge tilts it toward what they already believed about each person.

Why the surest view should move least

A result is news only where it differs from what you expected of someone.

What to credit

Parts a record or you can point to, in full; the rest to the team, equally.

Applies where several people shaped a result and no one can see who did what beyond the parts anyone can point to.

Asking the people involved does not settle it

The usual first step is to ask. In 1979 the psychologists Michael Ross and Fiore Sicoly asked people in joint work how much of it was theirs [1]. They studied married couples, discussion groups, basketball players and graduate students. People recalled more of their own contributions than of the others', and they took more responsibility than the others gave them. The authors stress that this can happen "in the absence of deliberate deceit" [1]. People simply remember their own part better.

In one study, 37 married couples each rated their share of 20 household activities. In 27 of the couples, the two partners' claims added up to more than the whole. The average overclaim was small, but it showed up on 16 of the 20 activities, including negative ones such as causing arguments [1]. People were not just claiming the good parts. Their own part came to mind more easily.

The answer also moved with the question. Graduate students were asked about responsibility for their thesis. Students whose questions focused on the supervisor's contributions gave the supervisor 33.3 percent of the responsibility. Students whose otherwise identical questions focused on their own contributions left the supervisor 16.5 percent [1]. The authors suggest the cause is what comes to mind first, though they do not claim proof [1].

So you cannot simply take an honest account of who did what as the true split. It leans toward the person telling it and shifts with how you ask. Collecting more accounts gives you more material, but someone still has to divide the result. That someone is you.

What fills the gap you cannot see

What does an honest judge do with a split they cannot see? The clearest evidence comes from studies of gender. The point is not that you hold a gender bias. Gender is simply where researchers have measured this most carefully.

Heather Sarsons, Klarita Gërxhani, Ernesto Reuben and Arthur Schram ran two experiments [2]. In the first, 506 people predicted how well others would do on a second quiz. The quiz takers had worked alone and were paid on their own scores, and the predictors were told so. Some predictors saw each person's own score. Others saw only the total for a pair, one man and one woman. With individual scores, the predictors treated men and women alike. With only the total, they predicted the woman would score about 0.24 points lower than the man, on a math quiz scored out of five. In fact, women had averaged 2.51 and men 2.72. Showing predictors those real averages did not change their predictions [2]. So this experiment shows a belief filling a gap the predictors could not see. It does not show the belief was wrong.

The second experiment shows it can be wrong. The researchers asked 479 people who recruit staff for a living to hire from short resumes for tasks on which men and women perform about the same [2]. When recruiters saw each candidate's own score, gender did not affect their choices. When they saw only scores for pairs, their choices followed their own beliefs about which gender is better at the task. The authors found that those beliefs explained most of the effect (it was "largely mediated" by them) [2]. Some of it was not explained by beliefs at all.

The same researchers studied tenure decisions for about 610 economists at 35 leading US departments from 1985 to 2014 [2]. Economics lists authors in alphabetical order, so a paper with several authors does not show who did what. Women started with a lower tenure rate. Each extra paper written alone raised women's chances by 15.5 percentage points and men's by 9.5. The authors read this as committees updating a lower starting belief about women "as they receive clear signals" [2]. Papers written with others worked differently. Each one raised men's chances by 7.4 points and women's by only 4.7 [2].

A second line of research shows the same pattern with a different kind of belief: how well known a person already is. Ginger Zhe Jin, Benjamin Jones, Susan Feng Lu and Brian Uzzi studied what happens to scientists after a paper they wrote with others is withdrawn for an error [3]. In the cases they studied, no one could tell which author was at fault. Citations to the earlier work of less well-known coauthors fell sharply. Well-known coauthors saw "modest if any decline" [3]. But when one author was plainly to

blame, because the same person appeared on several withdrawn papers, "prior reputation does not appear germane" [3]: how well known someone was no longer mattered. This study is about blame for a failure, not credit for a success.

Put the studies side by side. They cover a quiz experiment, a hiring experiment, tenure records and citation records, and two kinds of belief: a belief about a group, and how well known a person is. The pattern is the same in each. Where no one can see who did what, the earlier belief steers the split. Where individual parts are visible, the evidence overrides the belief. This paper reasons that other beliefs about who is good at a kind of work, such as seniority or who built or presented the tool, act the same way. The studies did not measure that step.

What about what you saw yourself? Specific pieces and decisions you saw for yourself count as parts you can point to. On this paper's reasoning, the belief takes over beyond those pieces, in your sense of who "really drove it." And what a sponsor sees is itself selective. Ross and Sicoly suggest that thesis supervisors miss the hours students spend running studies and drafting, while students miss the thinking the supervisor did before they joined [1]. The authors offer that as a likely cause, not a finding. They did not apply it to sponsors; this paper does, because a sponsor sees the steering meetings and the demonstrations more than the work between them.

Why your view of the person you were surest of should move least

None of this makes the sponsor's guess unfair. When no one can see the split, guessing it from what you know of each person is a reasonable estimate. Jin and his colleagues treat it exactly that way in their model [3].

The mistake comes next, when the guessed share is added to the person's standing as if it were new evidence. A result tells you something new about a person only to the extent it differs from what you expected of them. Jin and his colleagues put it this way: when you are already sure about someone, "having a tight prior about the individual means that new events will have little further effect on beliefs" [3]. For the person you were surest of, the success was mostly what you expected. Giving that person the largest share and adding it to their standing treats what you had already predicted as if it were news. Whatever the result showed beyond your expectations has no visible owner. Their model is about blame. They suggest the same reasoning applies to credit for good results but know of no data on it, and they warn that for a success, attention to a well-known member can lift the whole team, so the balance may differ [3].

The tenure data show what the usual way of dividing credit did to two groups. A paper written with others raised men's chances by 7.4 points and women's by 4.7. Women who wrote all their papers with others were tenured at about 37 percent, against 72 percent

for men who did the same. Women who wrote all their papers alone were tenured at rates similar to men's [2]. These are patterns across groups. The authors could not rule out that real or believed differences in effort explain part of the gap; their experiments, where effort played no part, point the same way [2]. This paper reasons that the same thing happens to the people on one program; the data do not show it. But the pattern shows what joint success did here: it lifted both groups, and it lifted most the group the judges already favored. Only work whose authorship was clear closed the gap.

The researchers also found that men gained about as much from a paper written with another man as from one written alone. They name two explanations: committees "making a mistake when dividing credit," or "an alternative mechanism," such as using joint work as an excuse to favor men, which they test and argue cannot fully explain the pattern. Of the idea that each committee credits its own man with the whole paper, they say "it is impossible to evaluate such theories with these data" [2]. So treat it as a warning, not a finding.

Now take the strongest objection: "My view of my own people is not a stereotype. It rests on years of their work." That may be true, and if so it keeps its full weight in their standing. The point is narrower. A result your view predicted should not be counted again as fresh proof of that view. And ask where the confident view came from. If it was built from earlier team results divided the same way, this paper reasons, it is less independent evidence than it feels.

The result is still real news about the team. In the hiring experiment, recruiters strongly favored candidates from the higher-scoring pair [2]. A team success should lift everyone on it. And the people you did not expect to drive it still gain, just less than they should. In the tenure data, women still gained 4.7 points per joint paper, not nothing [2].

Why holding back is the cheaper mistake

Refusing to count the guessed share has a cost. Sometimes the person you were sure of really did drive the result, and the rule under-credits them. The rule accepts that risk to avoid a worse one: over-crediting someone who was wrongly favored. That trade is the paper's judgment, and the reason follows.

Over-crediting feeds itself. It raises the person's standing. That standing shapes how you divide the next joint result, which raises it again. And by the argument above, joint results cannot reveal the mistake. Under-crediting is limited. The person's earlier standing stays where it was, they receive the team's share like everyone else, and making their parts visible removes the problem. A real driver who feels under-credited may still leave. The answer is the same: every part they did that can be pointed to is credited in full, so the fix is to make more of their work visible, not to fall back on the guess.

Giving the guessed share half its weight does not fix this. Any weight on a guessed share still moves standing in the direction of your earlier belief, only more slowly. That is why the team's share is split equally. Equal shares are the plainest division that does not hand the result out according to what you believed before. They do give someone who coasted the same team share as someone who carried unseen work. That is part of the cost the rule accepts: a person who carried the work gains through every part that can be pointed to, and a person who coasted shows few such parts.

None of this dilutes the credit of the person who carried the work. A part you can point to is credited in full.

Why more ratings after the fact do not fix it

The usual remedy for doubt is more input: ask peers, run a 360 review. This paper reasons that this does not, by itself, fix the problem. Peers asked afterward to divide a joint result face the same gap you do, filled with their own beliefs. And each person's account leans toward their own part, as Ross and Sicoly found [1].

Accounts written at the time, describing specific pieces, are different. They name parts you can point to, and the record proposed below is built from them.

The strongest objection is that a mixed panel would cancel out each judge's beliefs. In the hiring experiment, male recruiters leaned against the woman in a pair and female recruiters leaned toward her. Across all recruiters, the average effect of gender was not statistically significant [2]. So averaging judges with opposite beliefs can cancel them. But those were individual choices averaged together, not a panel talking it through. And averaging cancels a belief only where judges lean in different directions. A group that shares a belief about who is good at a kind of work keeps it.

Making the parts visible

In every study above, the earlier belief stopped steering the split when individual parts were clear: individual scores, an author plainly at fault, work written alone [2, 3]. Sociology offers a hint from the other side. It lists authors in order of how much they contributed, and there the authors found no penalty for women who wrote with others. They caution that this may instead reflect sociology's larger share of women [2].

None of the studies here shows that a written record changes how a judge divides credit. The closest test among them failed. In one of Ross and Sicoly's studies, pairs solved a problem together for 45 minutes while each kept brief notes on either their own or their partner's comments. Two or three days later, they reviewed their notes and rated who had controlled the discussion. Which person the notes covered had "no reliable impact"

on their ratings, and the lean toward the self remained [1]. The authors suspect the notes were too short, about a page, and that much of what was written seemed irrelevant to the decisions. The study did not compare notes with no notes [1].

The record proposed here differs from those notes in three ways. These differences are the paper's judgment, not a tested result. First, it lists which pieces each person did and which decisions they shaped, not what was said. Second, the people named confirm it while the work is fresh. A record can carry its writer's own view of which pieces mattered, and confirmation by the people named guards against that. Third, you read it before you form your view, rather than the contributor reviewing their own notes afterward.

It does not need percentages. In work where people depend on each other, there is often no clean share to record. The earlier belief works on the part no one can see, so every piece made visible leaves it less to fill. Judging how much each listed piece mattered can let the belief back in. That is one more reason the people named confirm the record, and why the team share, not your weighting, takes what the record cannot settle.

Keeping a record of who did what is not new. Team appraisal guides, role charts and work logs all do some version of it. What this paper adds is the order and the limit: read the record before you divide the result, and do not raise anyone's standing past what it shows.

Why this matters in AI programs

AI program results are joint by nature. They depend on data work, on the managers who change how the work is done, on the program lead, on technical staff and on vendors. So the split is rarely visible.

The belief about who is good at AI work is also new. In this paper's judgment, it tends to credit whoever built or demonstrated the tool, and it is crude and confidently held; none of that is a measured finding. Where parts stay unseen, a belief like that steers the split and never gets corrected.

The cost shows up in careers. Sarsons and her colleagues reason that people who learn that joint work earns them little will do less of it [2]. They do not measure this. But AI programs depend on exactly that joint work.

What to change

Before results are known, have the pieces of the work written down as they are done: who did which part, and which decisions it shaped. Have the people named confirm their entries while the work is fresh. Roles can be recorded the same way. A role becomes a guess only when it is used to infer how much of the result came from that person.

When the result arrives, read that record before you form a view. Credit each person in full for the parts it shows, and for anything you saw them do yourself. Credit the rest of the success to the team, equally to every member. Do not raise anyone's standing beyond that, even for the person you are sure drove it. Their earlier standing keeps its weight; the result it predicted is simply not counted twice. And because you were already surest of them, the same equal share is the least news about them, so their standing should move least of all.

The argument has limits. It rests on laboratory and hiring experiments, tenure records in economics and citation records in science. Carrying it to AI programs is an analogy. The study of earlier reputation concerns blame for a failure, not credit for a success; its authors know of no data on how credit for good results is shared and warn that the balance may differ. None of the studies shows that a record made at the time changes how a sponsor judges; that step is this paper's judgment. The paper does not say leaders deserve no credit for leading, or that a record guarantees fair credit.

The question for the sponsor changes from "Who drove this result?" to "Which parts of this result can I point to, and who did them?"

Sources

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